

Joining multiple main clauses

Sometimes three (or more) main clauses are joined together. If the resulting sentence is a list of main clauses containing similar ideas, a comma is used to separate the first two main clauses, and a conjunction is used before the third clause.

A comma is used to separate the first two main clauses in a list of three clauses.

Ali loves swimming, Aidan builds robots, and Sophie enjoys reading.

A coordinating conjunction is used to join the third main clause to the second main clause.

Using semicolons

Another way to form a compound sentence is to link two main clauses using a semicolon. A semicolon performs the same role as a conjunction, and can therefore be replaced by a conjunction. It shows that two clauses are closely related and equally important.

The two main clauses are giving two different, but closely related, pieces of information about Aidan, so they can be linked using a semicolon.

Aidan builds robots; he also repairs motorcycles.

The same two clauses can also be linked using a conjunction.

Aidan builds robots, and he also repairs motorcycles.

Using colons

A colon can also be used to form a compound sentence. Rather than connecting two similar ideas, a colon is used to show that the second main clause is an explanation of the first main clause. Unlike a semicolon, a colon cannot be replaced by a conjunction.

**Aidan has an unusual hobby:
He builds robots.**

These two main clauses are linked using a colon, because the second clause is an explanation of the first clause.

GLOSSARY

Coordinating conjunction A word that connects words, phrases, and clauses of equal importance.

Main clause A group of words that contains a subject and a verb and makes complete sense on its own.

Subject The person or thing that is performing the action of the verb.

Subordinate clause A group of words that contains a subject and a verb but depends on a main clause for its meaning.



• **Never use a comma to join two main clauses.** Main clauses can only be connected using a conjunction, a semicolon, or a colon.

• If the two **main clauses** use the **same subject** and are linked using a **conjunction**, the subject can be left out of the second clause. If the sentence is short, no comma is required before the conjunction. For example, "Ali loves swimming **but** hates running."